our lives, we human beings merge with Brahman, we cannot be separated from it any more than the salt can from the water in your bowl.

Since God is everywhere and in everything, this all-pervasive Universal Spirit is *nirguna*, without qualities, without shape and without gender; Hindus cannot refer to *nirguna* Brahman as 'He', since God can be and is also 'She' and 'It'. The Vedas use the interrogative pronoun '*ka*' (who?), or more precisely *kasmai* (to whom?) for the unknowable God. The impersonal pronoun often used in Sanskrit for God is '*tat*', 'that' in English; in other words, that which exists. Hindu meditation begins with the words '*Om tat sat'*: *Om*, the primordial sound that encompasses past, present and future; *tat*, that which exists; *sat*, Truth. The *Chandogya Upanishad* tells the story of Svetaketu, who is taught metaphysics by his father in a series of lessons that each end with the statement '*Tat tvam asi*'—'That you are'—that you are the same as the Brahman that pervades the cosmos.

As the *Hiranyagarbha* hymn in the *Rig Veda* asks:

> *O Father of the Earth, by fixed laws ruling*
> *O Father of the Heavens, pray protect us,*
> *O Father of the great and shining Waters!*
> *What God shall we adore with our oblation?*
>
> — *Rig Veda*, I.121.9[12]

But the sages realised that all this was rather abstruse, and would be difficult for the average human being to comprehend. The *nirguna* Brahman was a philosophical concept at the heart of Hinduism, but people needed to worship something they could imagine and visualise. Hence the idea of the *saguna* Brahman—the Absolute given form, qualities and attributes, also known as Ishvara or Bhagavan. Strictly speaking, Ishvara is the best translation of God in the Christian or Allah in the Muslim sense of these terms, since those faiths have no equivalent for God in the sense of Brahman. But the Hindu Ishvara takes multiple forms: there is the trinity of Brahma (the Creator), Vishnu (the Preserver) and Shiva or Mahesh (the Destroyer), all different manifestations of the God Principle, and their myriad manifestations, plus their *avatara*s, consorts and companions, who may all be worshipped depending on the preferences of the devotee. The *avatara* doctrine—under which these